It is a good thing that I picked up this book after a soul-satisfying meal, so I wouldn't drool. Or at least that's what I repeatedly told myself while turning the pages of Zac O'Yeah's newest book. *Digesting India* is a wild ride across the subcontinent's delectable culinary landscape, which the Scandinavian-origin author has explored over the past 30-odd years.

However, it wouldn't be right to call *Digesting India* a food book. It extends beyond the purview of the culinary and infuses the writer's anecdotes from his travels across India, ties in the lives of literary greats influenced by the country (think E.M. Forster's love for Hyderabadi food or the spiritually-minded W. Somerset Maugham's time in Kozhikode), and provides history lessons to give context to consumption. I myself made a mental note to visit Thalassery if only to devour 'kallumakkai' (or mussels), like the author did after a train ride conversation with a couple who couldn't stop raving about the shellfish. Unlike O'Yeah, I didn't grow up eating mussels, but in North Kerala, I could savour the edible heritage of the ancient spice trade that linked India with the Roman Empire.

Apart from eating and travelling, this book is also an homage to India's drinking history from the author's personal standpoint. O'Yeah evocatively takes readers on a journey from old-school beer halls and Bengaluru's hoppy history to the town locally known as 'Beershop' about two hours away. He searches for toddy and finds the 'shaap of shaaps' in an unpretentious whitewashed establishment in Pinayari. He hobnobs with Orhan Pamuk drinking exquisite village-distilled cashew feni at Amitav Ghosh's party in Goa, experiences the wondrous culture of all-day street-style chai-drinking culture in Kolkata and, in Bhutan, finds 'the most beautiful' downmarket bars north of the Chubachhu Roundabout on a surprisingly sunny monsoon day walking about with a soaked shirt.

Apart from eating and travelling, **Digesting India** is also an homage to India's drinking history

While O'Yeah's words take a reader across India, through different cultures, historical structures and eating habits, he also digresses to a curious thought—what could a culinary tourist eat on the International Space Station? Well, based on O'Yeah's visit to NASA in Houston picking space food samples, on my trip I'm going to stay far away from the dried ice-cream bar that felt like a perfumed soap bar!

From eating desert beans (or acacia) in Churu to going on a 'spareparts' tour in Bengaluru's Shivajinagar, O'Yeah's writing is humorous, insightful, and delightful, tempting the reader to binge on this country's delectable, sometimes unknown, offerings on each page (I had to stop and get a midnight treat to curb my growling stomach as O'Yeah feasted on a pork thali sampler in Shillong).

Digesting India is unputdownable. When you finally finish, be prepared to feel hungry, for food and new adventures. ■

Sharmistha Chaudhuri

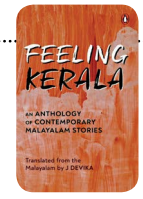
Timely Tales

J. DEVIKA HAS COMPILED A NUANCED ANTHOLOGY OF CONTEMPORARY SHORT STORIES FROM KERALA

currently with the Centre for Development Studies at Thiruvananthapuram''.

It's also evident from the often raw and unflinching recording of contemporary issues in Kerala that they are part of a deeper malaise, the delusions of civil society in clinging to a mythical past. Devika admits that her first instinct was to write a book herself. What she does instead is provide long introductions to each of the stories, perhaps with the intention of creating a context for them. For some of us, these interventions, however well meant, remain just that.

What is definitely admirable is that Devika has completely disregarded the current 'victimhood' narrative that so often defines portraits of a society in transition wedged between a feudal past and the current global or monetary imperatives. She brings together an astonishing range of narratives that leave the reader in awe of the relentless pursuit of truths by her young, often millennial writers.



FEELING KERALA
An Anthology of Contemporary Malayalam Stories
Translated from the Malayalam by J. Devika
PENGUIN
₹599; 304 pages

If we could agree on an index for the measurement of outrage, as we find on menus indicated by icons of green and red chillies, we could arrive at three Rs—Rage, Revenge, Retribution—that underly the accounts. 'The Funerary Palm' by Yama leads the list, while the last one, 'Like Wind, Sun, Leaf and Flower', by Shahina E.K., ends as a shock trooper. 'Null and Void', by P.V. Kumar, could be a reprise of a news item from puppet state governments today; 'Pothycchoru Offering' by Prince Ayamanam; 'The People of Idaveli' by Vinoy Thomas, 'K.P. Ummer' by Shihabuddin Poithumkaduvu; and 'Skyrocket' by G.R. Indugopan could signal the red chilli category. 'Rules for Drivers' by Santhosh Aechikkanam; 'The Temple of Vatsyayanan' by Unni R.; 'Green Room' by Dhanya Raj; 'Sanghiannan' by K.R. Meena; and 'Sujatha's Houses' by Nirmala might be rated with green chillis; while 'Neeraaliyan' by Ambikasutan Mangad—which is a fight for survival where a fisherman rescues a giant turtle devoid of its flippers destroyed by deep-sea fishing trawlers and brings it to his wife—deserves a whole new category. It could be called Compassion. ■

Geeta Doctor